

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Programming

Computer programs drive the world, and we can't tell you much about it in one column. Still, use these terms the correct way and they'll think you're way beyond "Hello, World!"

Argument: Hardly what it suggests, an argument is something you give a *method* (or function, or procedure) to operate upon. Like, "3" would be an argument for an addition *method*.

Class: Tricky one to explain, but think of it as a template for an object, amongst other things. For example, class "Digit" could be defined as having four sections, two covers, and one cover babe.

Concatenation: Putting together two *strings*, as in "bl" concatenated with "uff" gives "bluff".

Inheritance: The posh flat you get from your diabetic grandmother. No, seriously, it means the properties a *subclass* has in common with its parent *class*—as in, *class* "Digit1" could *inherit* the sections and covers, but no babe.

Instance: A tangible thing based on something abstract. Like "3" is an instance of an integer.

Invocation: Chants and all. Well, somewhat. You invoke a method by passing it its *arguments* and saying the magic word "Go!"

Literal: When "a" should be taken as the letter "a", not as an algebraic value, it's a literal.

Method: A piece of code that does a particular job.

Return: A *method* does its job and gives you something new to play with it—that is, it *returns* something.

String: A bunch of characters in a line. As in g-u-i-t-a-r makes the string "guitar".

Usage: I had three *strings*—all instances of my "Digit" *class*—which I *concatenated* with two *literals* to make up my *argument*. Now the "Tech" *method inherits* its *string* manipulation from the "Navigator" *class*, so I *invoked* it with that *argument* and it *returned* the same string but with the vowels!

Wild Wild Web

Subliminal!

This happened when the new PlayStation 3 was in the spotlight for the delayed release. One fine day, on the Web site of the PS3, the Apple logo flashed on a pic of the console, as you can see.

People began talking about Apple's latest venture. In about three and a half minutes, the Web was agog with speculation about what Apple was up to.

Some hinted at a Sony-Apple joint venture. One bit of frenzied guesswork was that Sony had bought Apple's Shake software, and was experimenting by adding watermarks of Apple's logo to the PS3.



It's a wild wild world—one logo, and people go hysterical. Imagine how clogged the pipes would have gotten if that logo had made it to the Microsoft site...

Dumb And Dumber

419 scams could account for a considerable portion of Nigeria's GDP, going by the facts and figures. The latest one is as hilarious—or boring—as the rest: a fake site purporting to be that of the London Metropolitan Police, www.metpoliceuk-gov.com. This one included an "anti-terrorist" hotline number. The

long and short of it is that the scam refers victims to a Web site—an official one, of course—that sells "anti-terrorist certificates," which are purportedly needed to secure payments from abroad. The Met Police reported it, and the site's no longer there. In case you didn't know, enterprising Nigerians have gone way beyond offering millions of dollars to be transferred to your bank account. In 2006, they launched sites for Interpol and the US Secret Service, amongst others. Why are these folks so dumb? As in, Who'd fall for these scams? But worse, how come people are dumb enough to make their efforts worth their while?

someone, and points are lost if you eat the food yourself. You get a level-up when someone burps.

Be God-Fearing: Read a scripture and you get points. Level up when you finish a chapter. Read porn and points get slashed. Steal a copy of *Penthouse* and then lie about it and it's game over.

Anti-AIDS: There's naked women all around. You lose points for leering, and gain points for getting into an exclusive relationship. Hunt for condoms: five points each. Level up at 150 points. Do the nasty without a condom in your bank, and it's Game Over!

ROBOTS AS WIVES

They're Crazy!

We've reported earlier that a UK government study had predicted that robots could demand the same rights as human beings within the next 50 years. We'd titled that bit of information "They're Crazy!"

Now, South Korea is a very forward-looking country, and the Ministry of Information and

Communication has predicted that every South Korean household will have a robot by the time we get to 2015 or 2020. In view of that, and also the fact that robots have already gone beyond being factory workers, they're drawing up some rules there—a formal set of rules, as in a charter.

Formally, it is an ethical code to prevent humans abusing robots and vice versa. The glibly-stated "Robot Ethics Charter" will cover standards for users and manufacturers. There's one science fiction writer aboard the team of experts that are putting up the Charter, so you can imagine the general flavour of the whole thing.

Now here's what the South Korean ministry of Commerce, Industry and Energy has said about it: "The government plans to set ethical guidelines concerning the roles and functions of robots as robots are expected to develop strong intelligence in the near future."

"Expected to develop"? "Strong intelligence"? English doesn't have a word for how silly that sounds, but "goofy" is probably closest.

The guidelines could reflect Isaac Asimov's Three Laws of Robotics, Park Hye-

Young of the ministry told the AFP news agency. The important considerations would include ensuring human control over robots, protecting data acquired by robots, and preventing illegal use. Incidentally, Asimov's Three Laws go, in short, as so: a robot may not injure a human being; a robot must obey orders given to it by human beings; a robot must protect its own existence.

Why does all this have a ring of balderdash to it? For the most part, it's because we can't get ourselves to believe robots will get that intelligent anytime soon, intelligent enough to merit a charter. And second, even if we were to assume that they would, why now? Why not wait for the robots to develop "strong intelligence," or at least get halfway there? Where's the tearing hurry?

You haven't heard the best yet. The same sane-sounding Park Hye-Young, who happens to be a woman, went on to say to AFP, "Imagine if some people treat androids as if the machines were their wives." That, we gather, is a polite way of saying men would try and have actual sex with female robots. No, sir. We do not see that happening. For